BSH PDF Importer User Guide

Oct 9, 2026 · @Dale

Contents

1. Overview
2. Getting started
3. Importing orders
4. Setting up unrecognized items
5. Column Mappings screen
6. Backing up and copying mappings
7. Test a PDF
8. Troubleshooting and FAQ

Overview

The BSH PDF Importer reads Bishop's Order for Food and Supplies PDFs and saves each order into the BSH Access database. Order details (order number, recipient, ward, storehouse) go into the `BSH` table, and each ordered item goes into its category table, such as `CannedMeats` or `DairyAndEggs`.

What you can do

Feature	Where	What it does
Import Order Form	Button on the main window	Saves one or more order forms or picklists to the database
Unrecognized Items	Opens during an import	Lets you set up items the app does not recognize, then retries the order
Column Mappings	Menu → Column Mappings…	View, add, edit, deactivate and annotate mappings
Export / Import JSON	Column Mappings screen	Back up mappings or copy them between databases
Test a PDF	Menu → Test a PDF…	Shows what an import would do, without saving anything

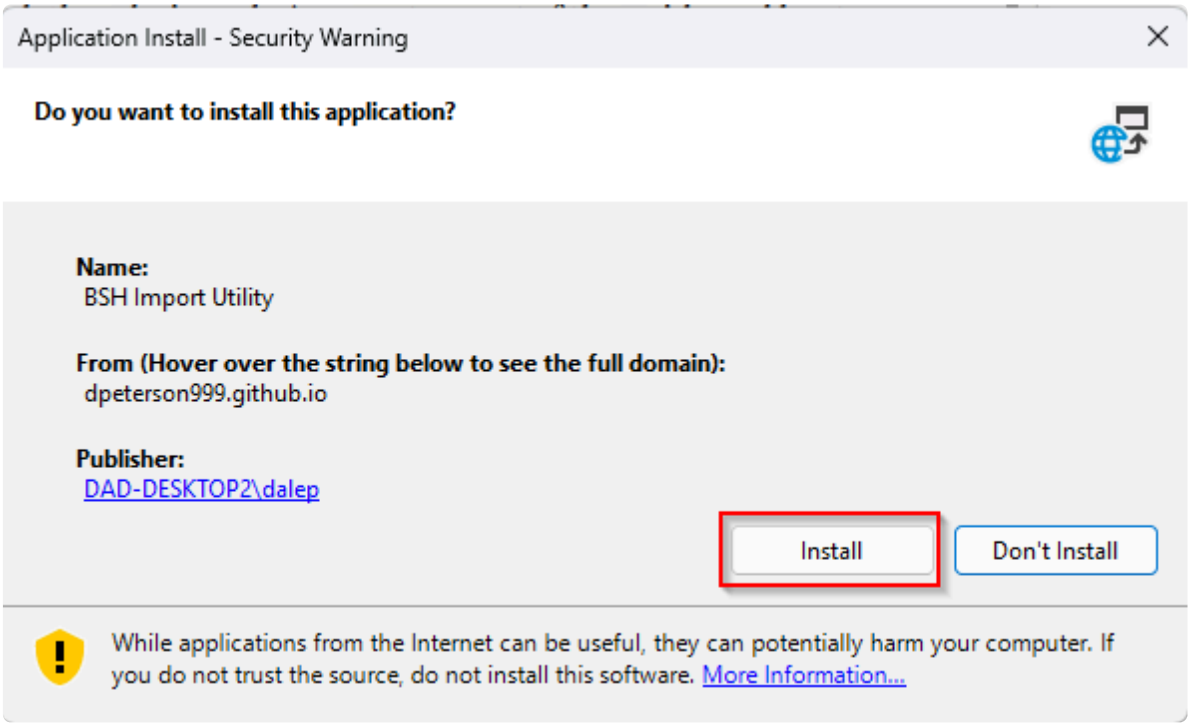
Access Database Location	Menu	Switch to a different database
Ignored Columns	Menu	Lists labels the import always skips
View Import Log	Menu	Opens the log of every import

Requirements

- A Windows PC
- The location of the BSH database file (ask whoever manages it)
- If the app can't open the database, ask your administrator to check that the Microsoft Access Database Engine is installed

Installing and updating

Download and run setup.exe, then click **Install** when Windows asks. It installs anything the app needs, then opens it. The app updates itself: a new version is picked up the next time it starts.

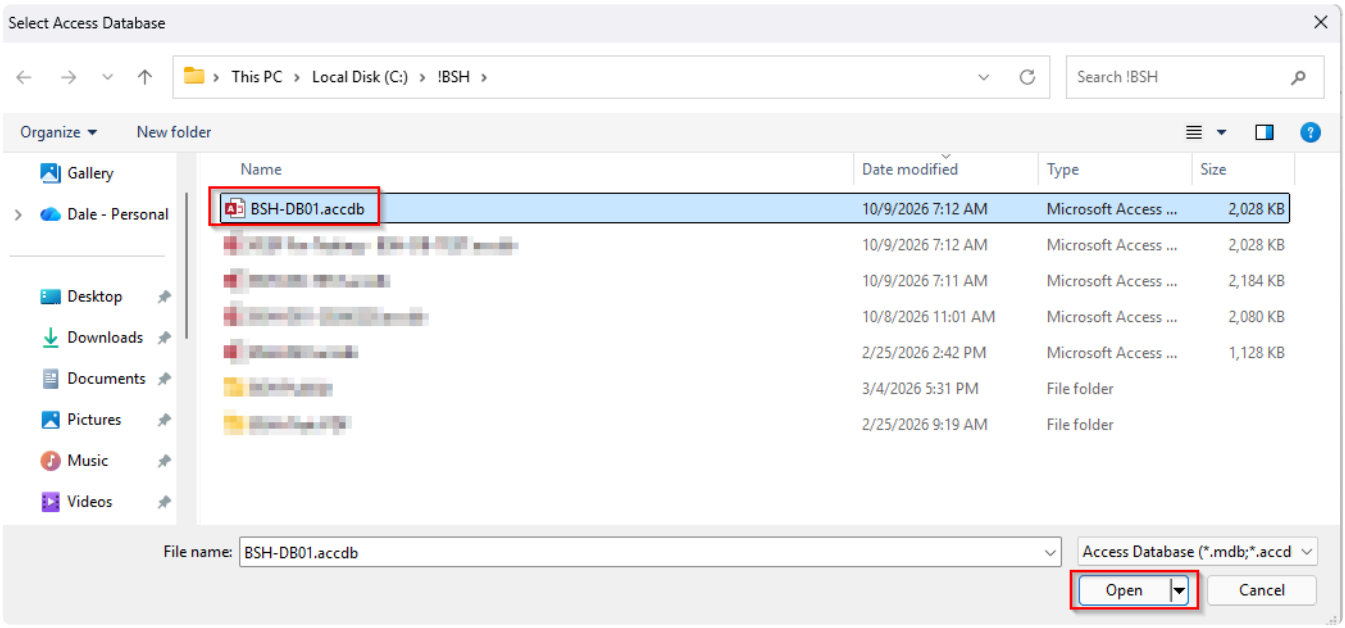


Getting started

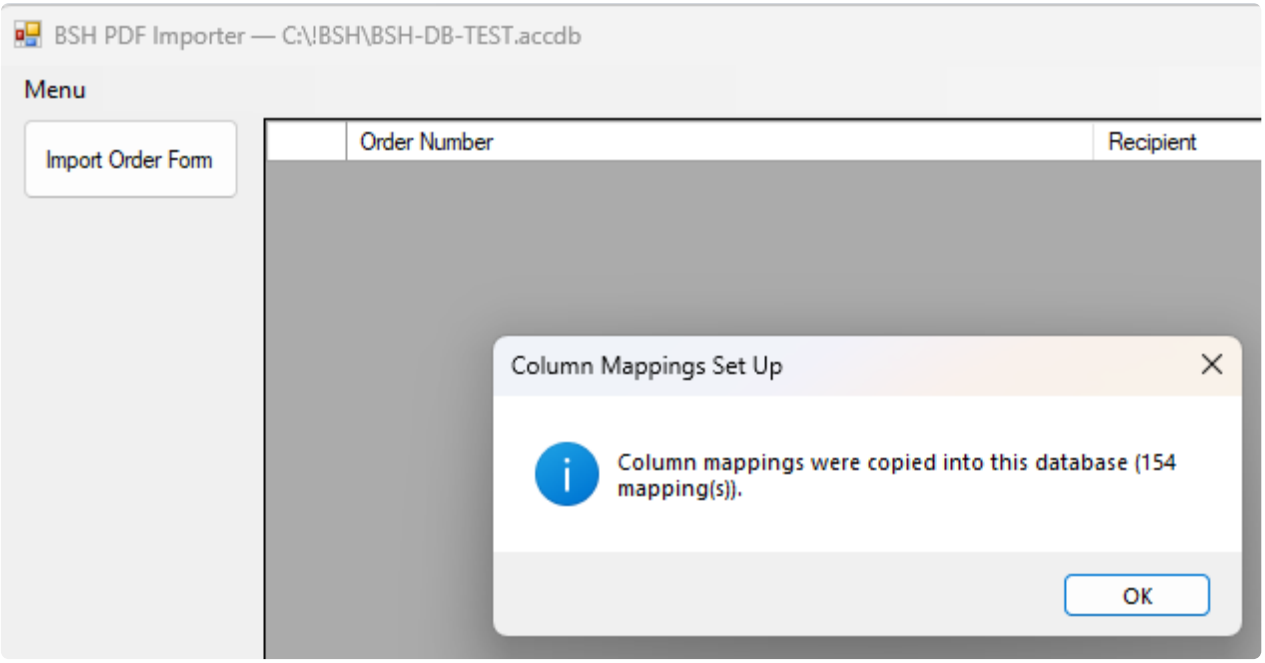
The first time you start the app, it asks you to pick the BSH Access database. After that, it remembers your choice.

Choosing the database

1. Start **BSH PDF Importer**.
2. In the **Select Access Database** window, find your `.accdb` or `.mdb` file and click **Open**.
3. If you cancel, the app asks again. It cannot run without a database.



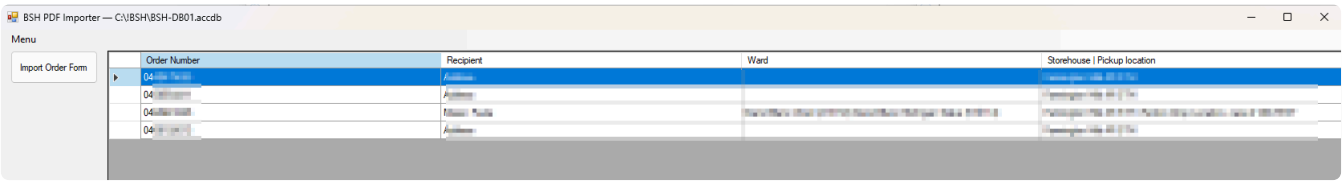
The first time the app opens a database, it sets up the item mappings for you and shows **Column Mappings Set Up** with the number of mappings copied in. Click **OK**.



The main window

The title bar shows the database you are working in: **BSH PDF Importer —** followed by its path. Always check it before importing.

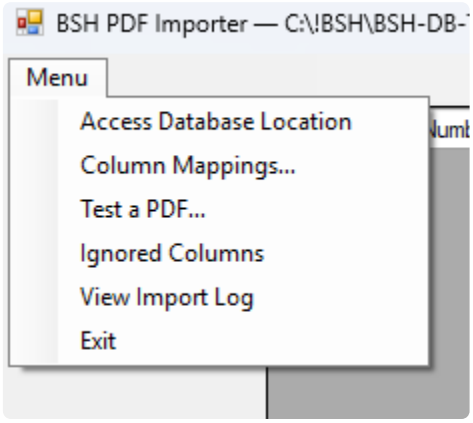
- **Import Order Form** button: starts an import.
- **Grid**: every order already in the database, with Order Number, Recipient, Ward and Storehouse | Pickup location.
- **Progress bar**: appears during an import.
- **Menu**: everything else.

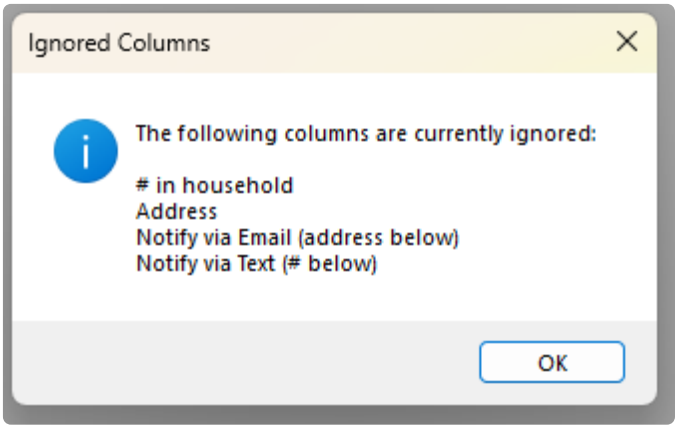


The Menu

Menu item	What it does
Access Database Location	Pick a different database. The app switches to it right away and remembers it.
Column Mappings…	Opens the Column Mappings screen.

Test a PDF…	Checks PDFs without importing them.
Ignored Columns	Lists labels the import always skips, such as `# in household` and `Address`, plus any you marked Ignore.
View Import Log	Opens the import log in your text editor.
Exit	Closes the app.
Help → User Guide (F1)	Opens this guide as a PDF. It is installed with the app, so it works without internet.
Help → About	Shows the app's version and the database it is using. Use it to check that an update arrived.



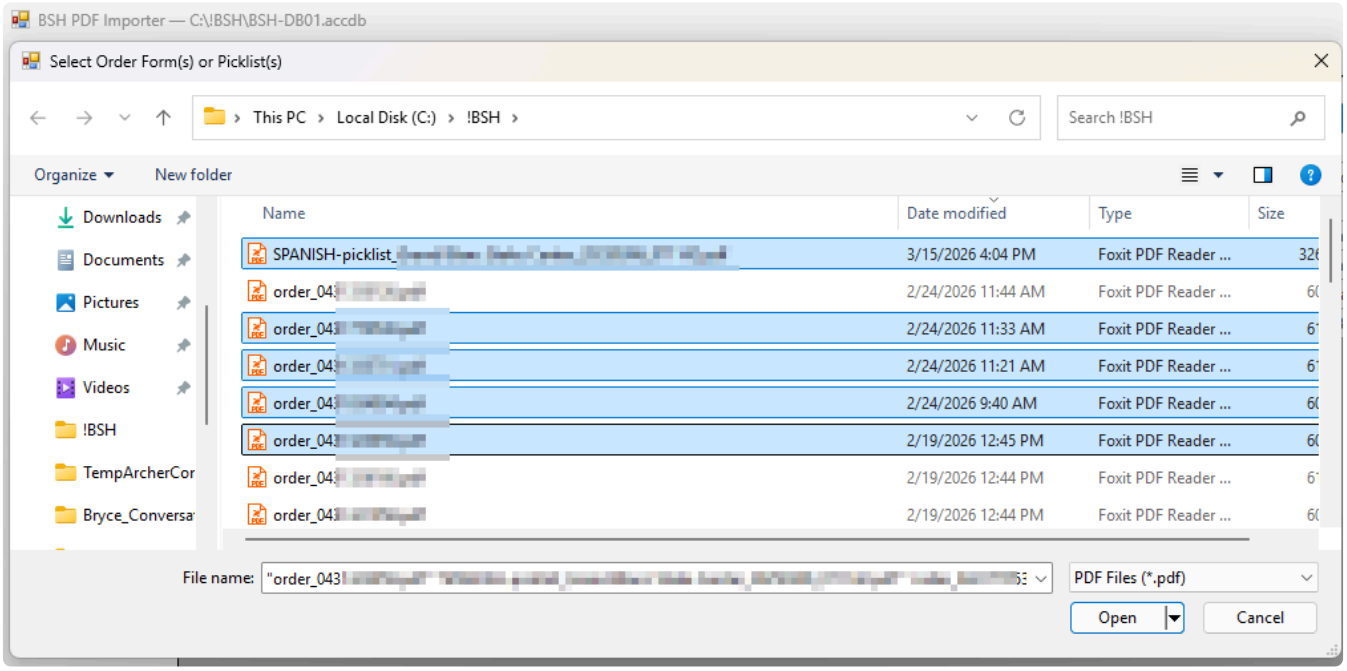


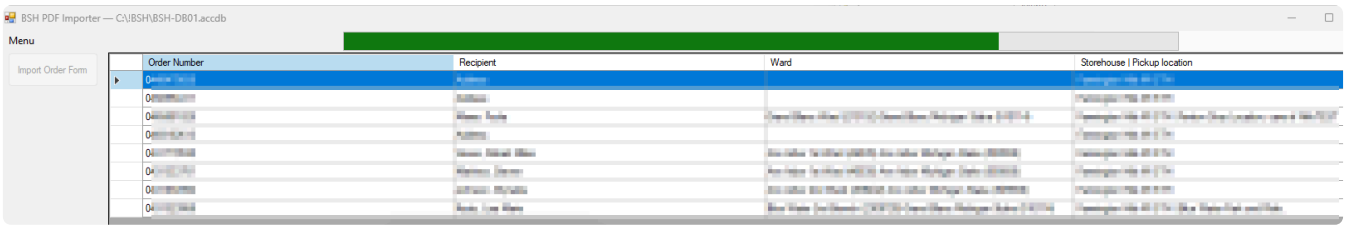
Importing orders

You can import single order forms, storehouse picklists, or a mix, several files at once. Each order is saved all at once or not at all, so a failed order never leaves partial data behind.

Steps

1. Check the title bar shows the right database.
2. Click **Import Order Form**.
3. In **Select Order Form(s) or Picklist(s)**, pick one or more PDFs. Hold **Ctrl** to pick several. Click **Open**.
4. Watch the progress bar. If an order has items the app does not recognize, the **Unrecognized Items** window opens (see the next section).
5. When the import ends, read any skipped-order messages, then the **Import Complete** message.
6. The grid refreshes and shows the new orders.





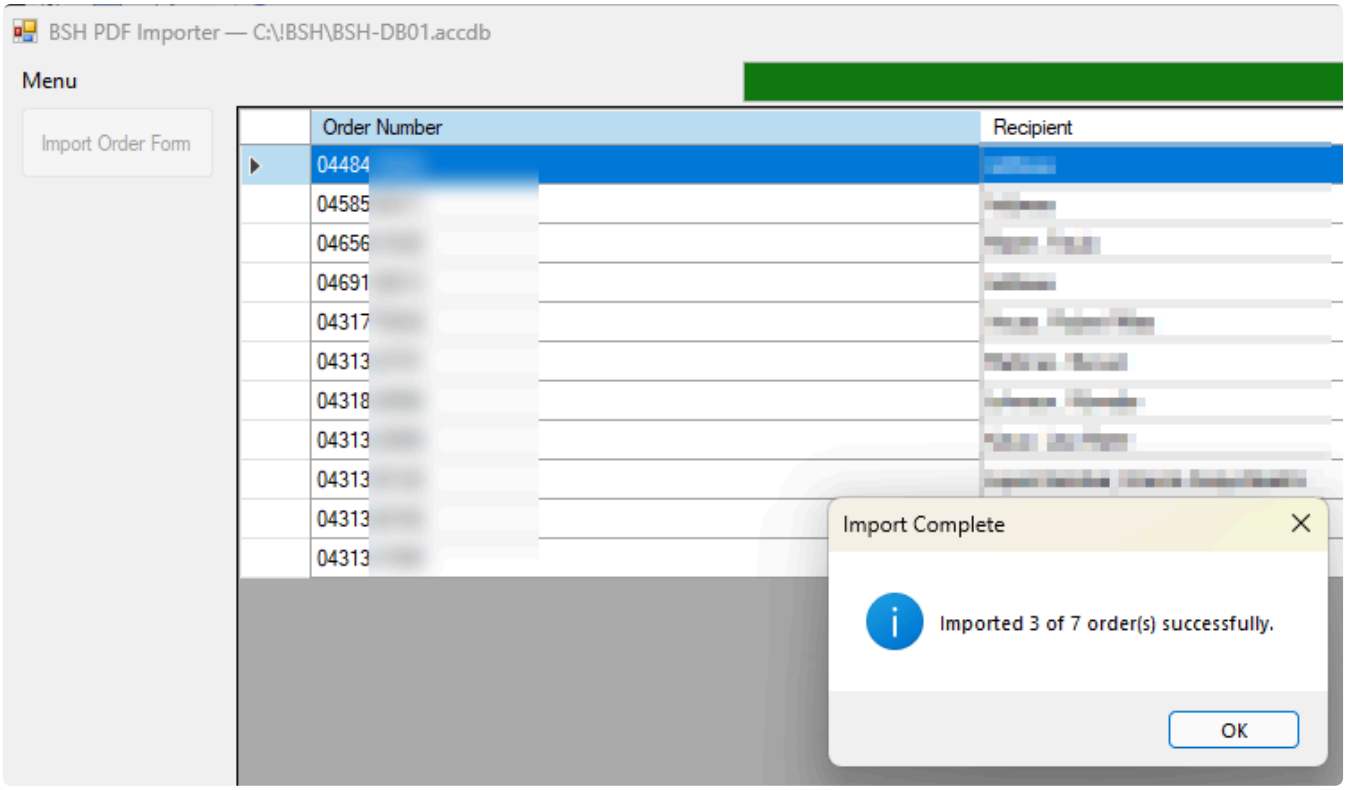
Picklists

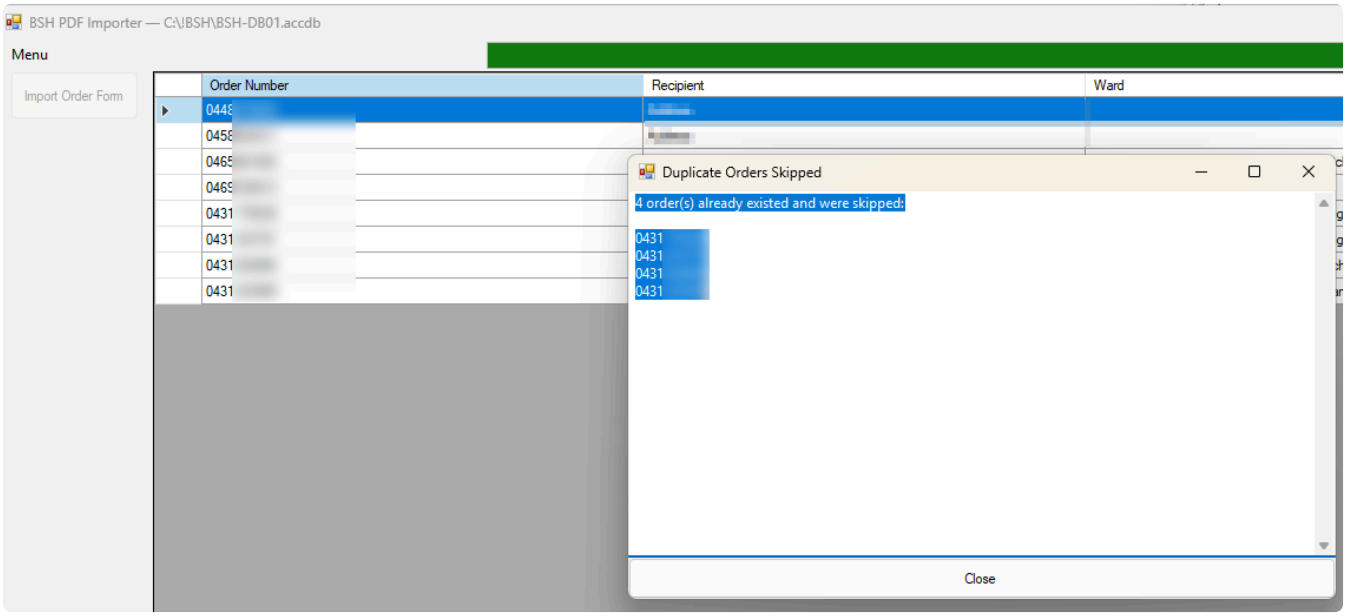
A storehouse picklist (a PDF whose first page says "Orders for Pickup or Delivery") is split automatically. The app skips the summary pages, then treats every two pages as one order. If no orders are found in a picklist, you see **No Orders Found** and that file is skipped.

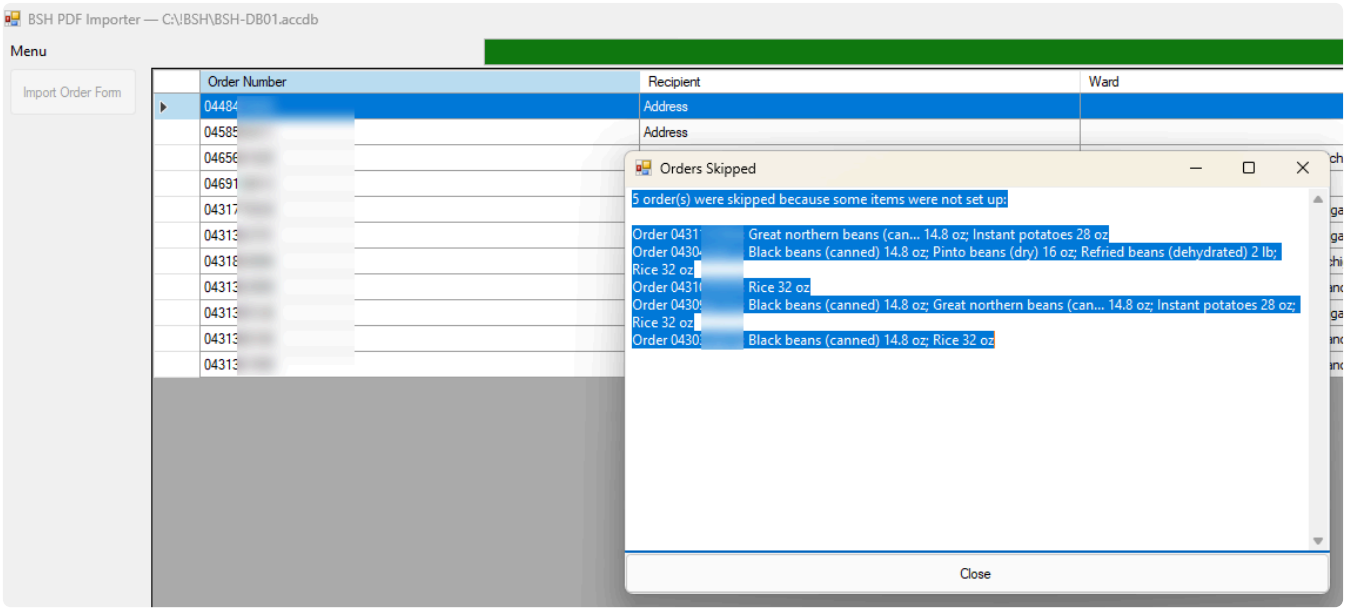
Messages at the end of an import

Message	What it means	What to do
Import Complete	"Imported X of Y order(s) successfully."	Nothing, unless X is less than Y. Read the messages before it.
Duplicate Orders Skipped	These order numbers are already in the `BSH` table.	Nothing. Each order is only imported once.
Orders Skipped	Some items were not set up and you chose Skip this order.	Import the file again and set up the items, or use Test a PDF first.
Invalid File	No order number was found. The file is not an order form.	Check you picked the right PDF.
PDF Parse Error	The PDF could not be read.	Open the PDF to check it is not damaged, then try again.
Error	Something went wrong saving the order. Nothing from that order was saved.	Read the message, check the import log, and try again.

The Duplicate Orders Skipped and Orders Skipped windows let you select and copy the text.

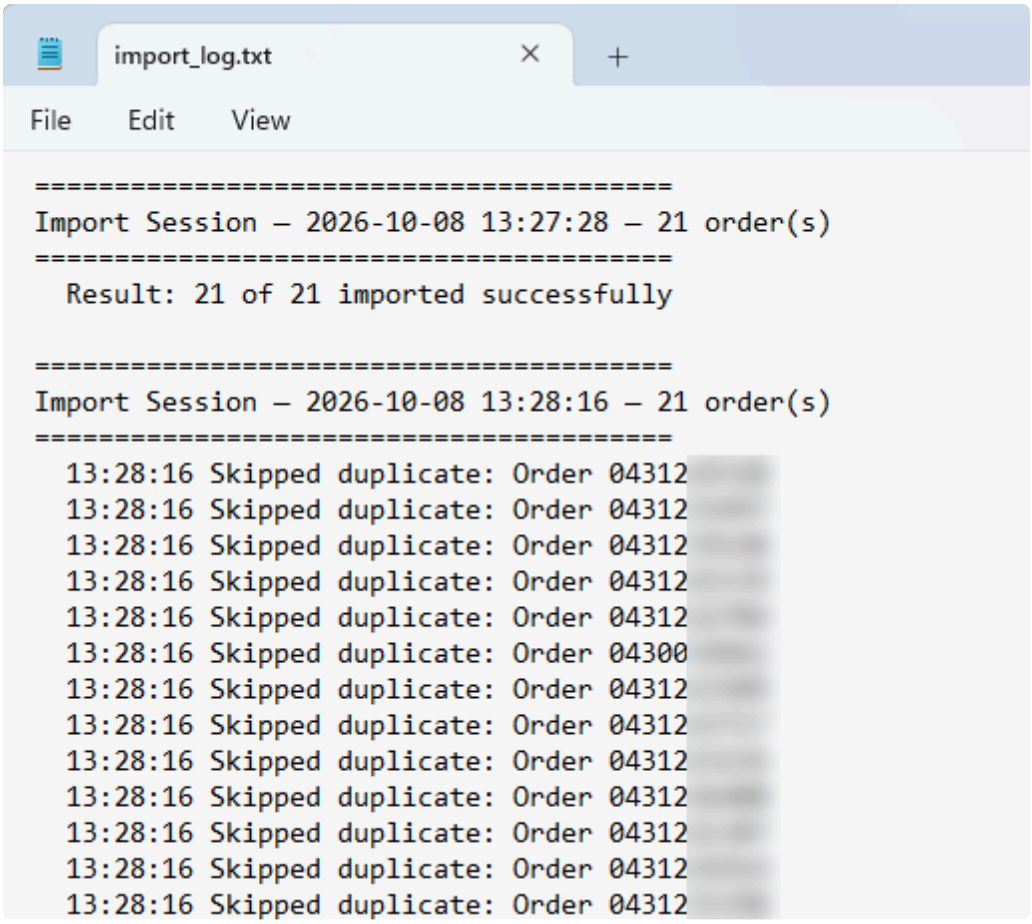






The import log

Every import is written to a log: what was imported, what was skipped, and every mapping saved along the way. Open it with **Menu → View Import Log**. The file is at `%AppData%\BSH Import Tool\import_log.txt`. Before your first import, the app says there is no log yet.



Setting up unrecognized items

When an order has a line the app does not know where to save, the import pauses that order and opens **Unrecognized Items**. Nothing from that order has been saved yet. Your choices are remembered, so you only answer once per item.

Why it happens

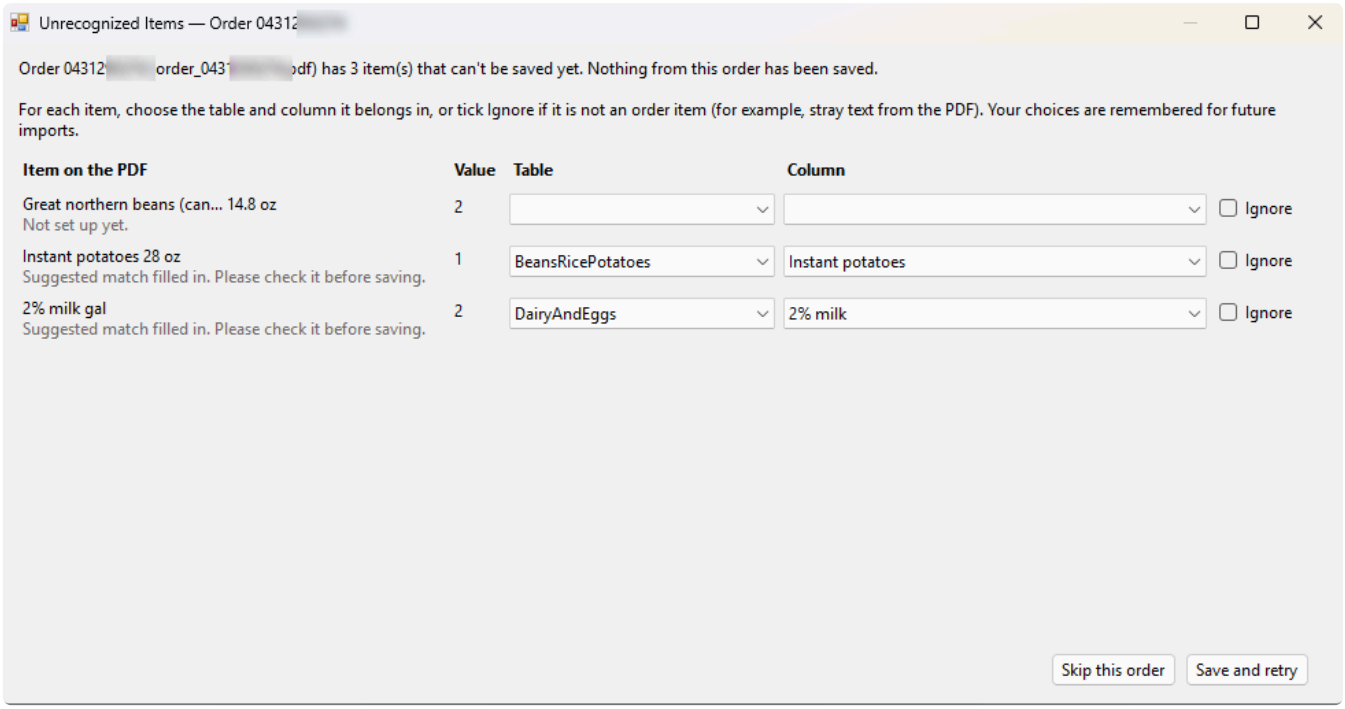
Every line on the order form, for example `Chili 14.4 oz`, needs a *mapping*: the table and column it is saved to (`CannedMeats → Chili`). An item shows up here when:

- it is new on the form, or its wording changed, so it has no mapping yet
- its mapping points to a column that no longer exists in the database
- its mapping was deactivated on the Column Mappings screen

The Unrecognized Items window

The title shows the order number. The grid lists each item with its value from the PDF, and a note underneath it:

Note	Meaning
Not set up yet.	No mapping. Choose a table and column.
Suggested match filled in. Please check it before saving.	The app found a likely match from similar items. Check it.
Was saved to Table → Column, which no longer exists in the database.	The column was renamed or removed in Access. Pick the new one.
Form section: BREADS.	Added to the note for items on the order form. It is the section the item is listed under; use it to pick the table.
Required order field.	One of the four fixed order fields (Order Number, Recipient, Ward, Storehouse). It cannot be changed here. If one looks wrong, contact your administrator.



Steps

1. For each item, choose the **Table**, then the **Column**.
2. If the line is not an order item, such as stray text from the PDF, tick **Ignore** instead.
3. If the item belongs in a table or column that hasn't been added to the database yet, tick **Not in database**. See *When an item isn't in the database yet* below.
4. Click **Save and retry**. The app saves your choices and imports the order again. If any item is ticked Not in database, the button reads **Save (order not imported)** instead.
5. Or click **Skip this order** to leave the order out. It is listed in the Orders Skipped message at the end.

When an item isn't in the database yet

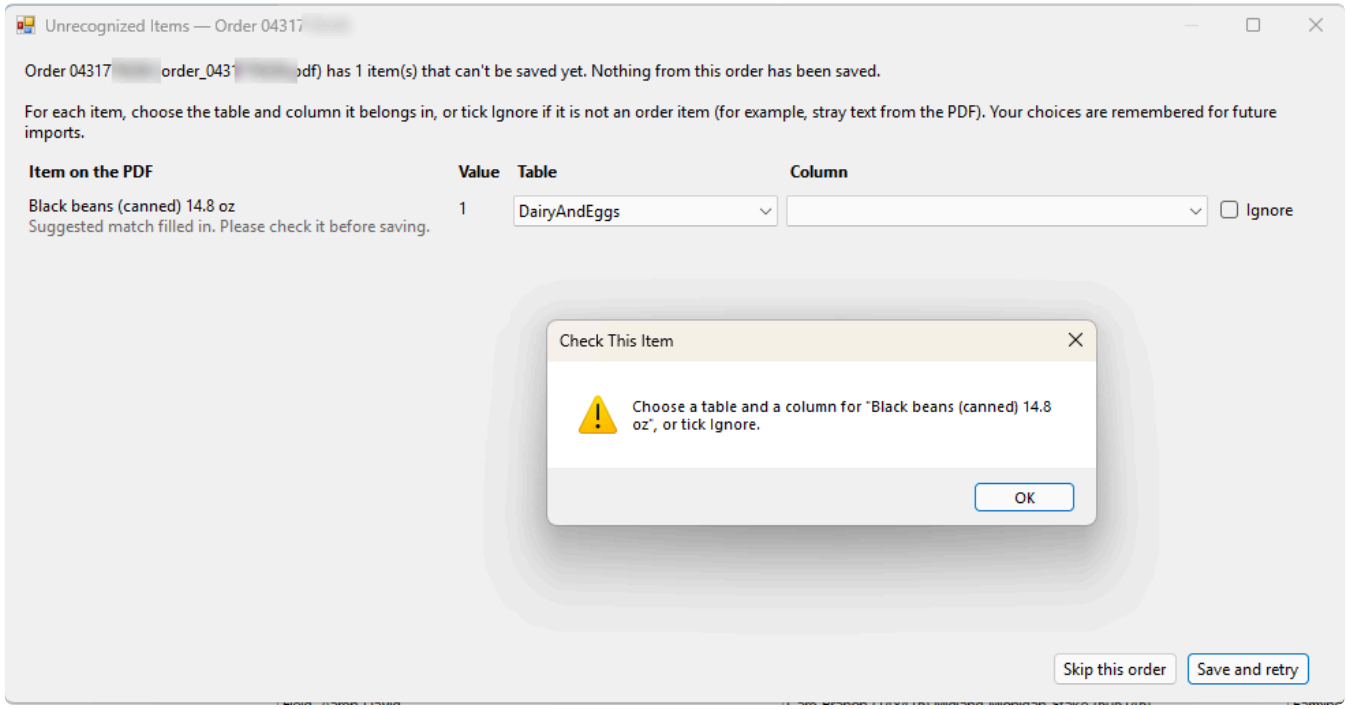
The app never adds tables or columns to the database. Your administrator adds them in Access. When you save with any item ticked **Not in database**:

- Your choices for the other items are saved.
- The order is not imported. It is listed in the Orders Skipped message at the end.
- The **Items Need Adding to the Database** window shows a note listing each item, its form section and what to add in Access. The note is already copied, so paste it into an email to your administrator.

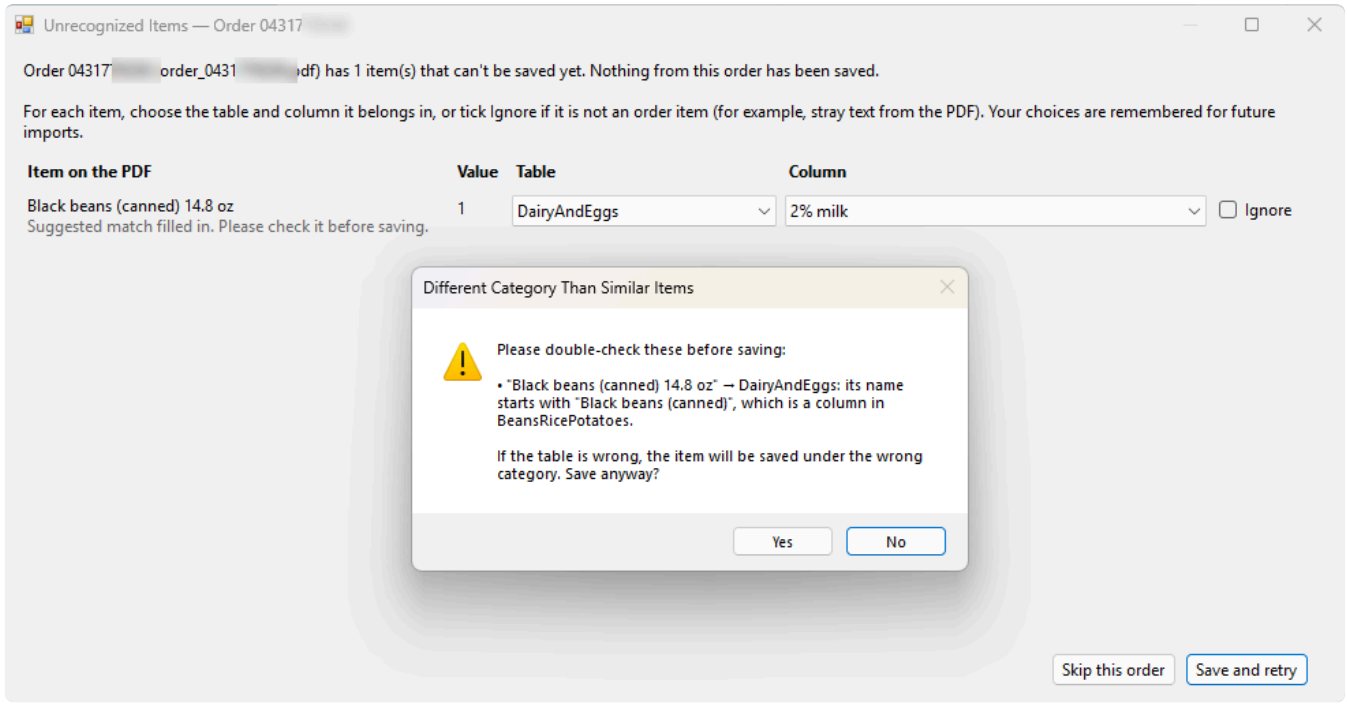
Once the column or table has been added, import the order again, or run **Test a PDF**. If asked, choose the new table and column.

Checks before saving

If a row is incomplete, **Check This Item** tells you what to fix, for example "Choose a table and a column, or tick Ignore."



If the table you picked differs from similar items, **Different Category Than Similar Items** asks you to double-check. For example, a soup labeled "Chicken noodle soup" saved under `CannedMeats`. A wrong category still imports "successfully", just under the wrong table, so read the warning carefully. Click **Yes** to save anyway, or **No** to go back.

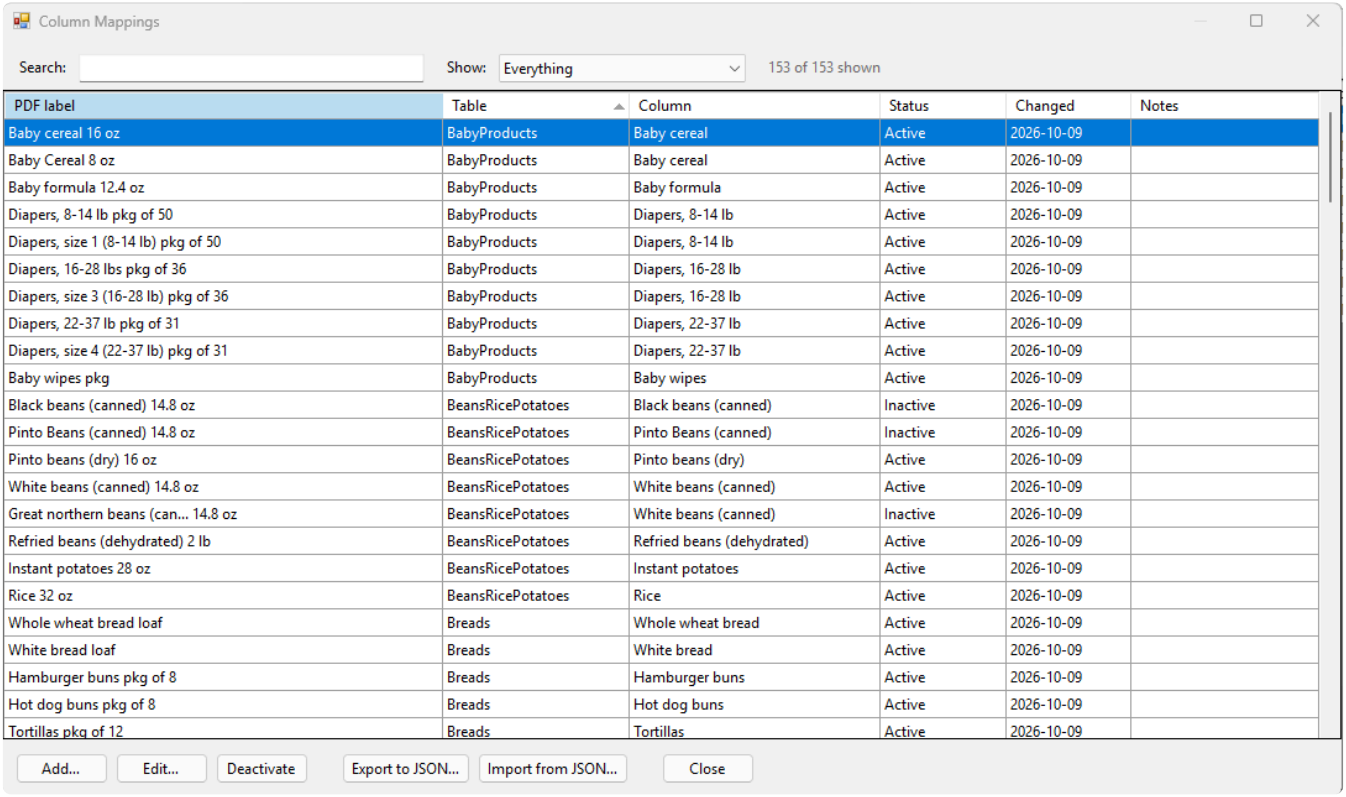


Several labels, one column

Many labels can point to the same column. This is how older and newer wording of the same item, such as `Salt 26 oz` and `Salt (iodized) 26 oz`, both land in `Seasonings → Salt`. The app does not warn about it.

Column Mappings screen

Menu → Column Mappings… lists every mapping in the database and lets you change them. Changes are saved in the database, so everyone who uses it sees them right away.



Reading the list

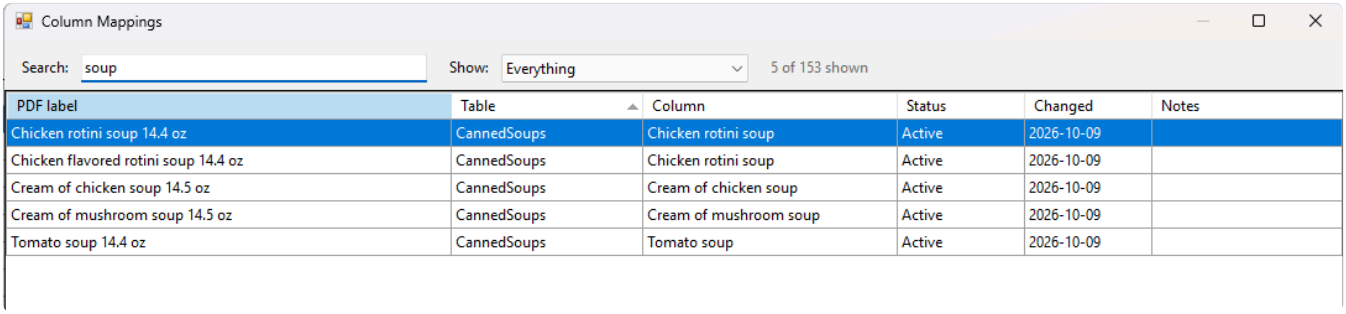
Each row shows the **PDF label**, **Table**, **Column**, **Status**, **Changed** date and **Notes**. Click a column header to sort. The count at the top shows how many rows are shown out of the total.

Status	Meaning	Colour
Active	Used by imports.	Normal

Required	One of the four fixed order fields. Cannot be changed.	Normal
Ignored	The label is skipped on import.	Grey
Inactive	Turned off. Orders with this label stop and ask again.	Grey
Missing column	Points to a table or column no longer in the database.	Red

Finding a mapping

- **Search:** type any part of a label, table, column or note.
- **Show:** pick Everything, Active mappings, Missing column, Ignored labels, Inactive, or Changed in the last 30 days.



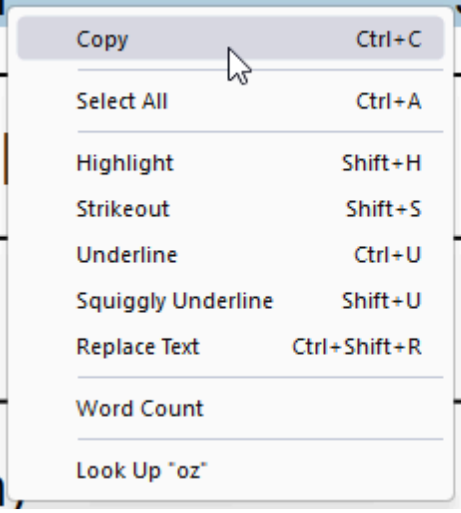
Adding a mapping

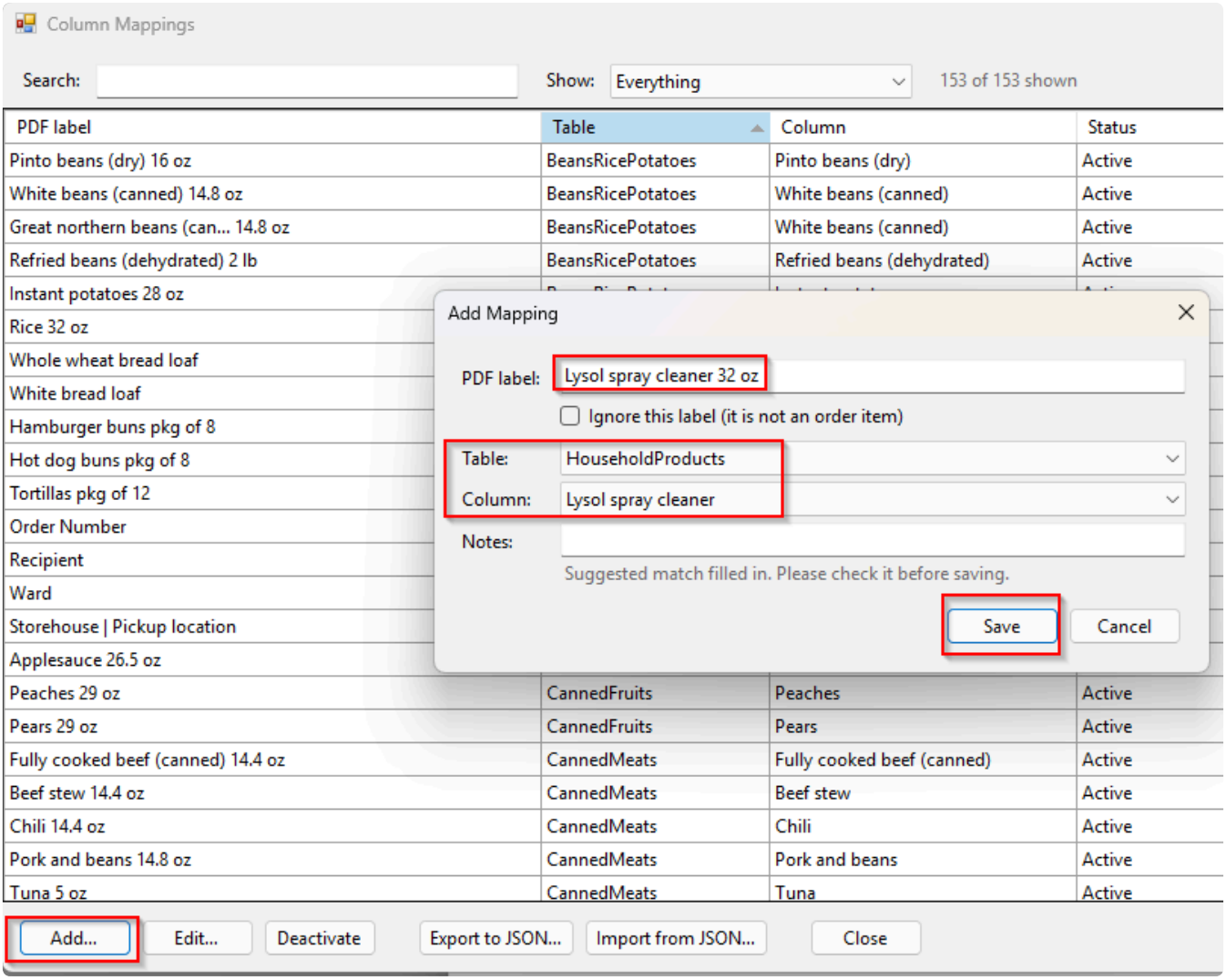
1. Click **Add…**.
2. Type or paste the **PDF label** exactly as it appears on the PDF. A matching table and column are suggested when there is a clear one.
3. Choose the **Table** and **Column**, or tick **Ignore this label (it is not an order item)**.
4. Optionally add **Notes**, for example why the mapping exists. Notes can be up to 255 characters.
5. Click **Save**.

If the label already has a mapping, even an inactive one, the app tells you to find and edit it instead. The same Different Category warning as the import applies.

Tip: to get the label exactly right, open the PDF, select the item's whole line, copy it, and paste it into **PDF label**.

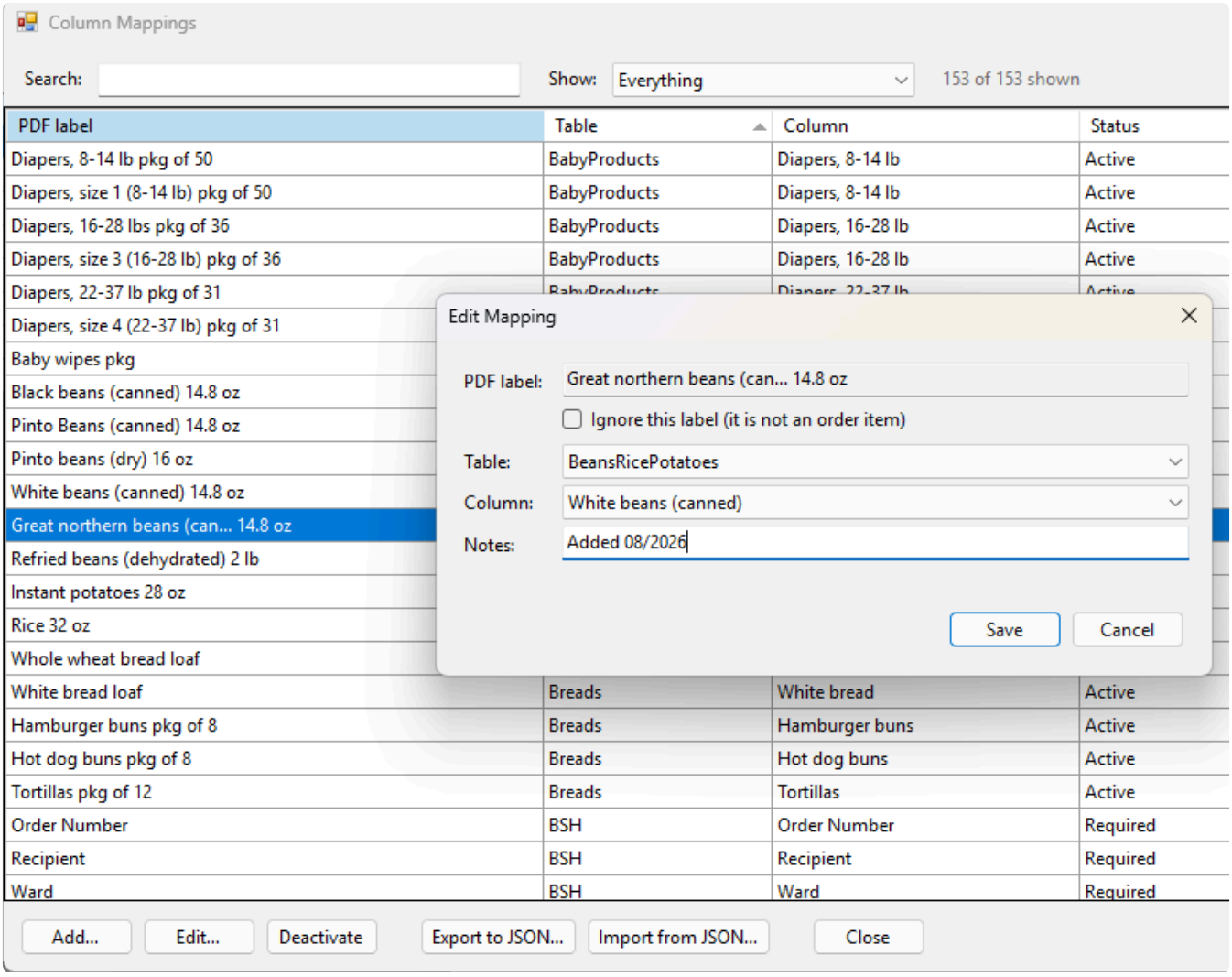
Automatic dishwasher liquid	42 fl oz
Laundry detergent	50 fl oz
Plastic wrap	roll
Lysol spray cleaner	32 oz
PERSONAL P	
Deodorant (men)	ea
Deodorant (women)	ea





Editing a mapping

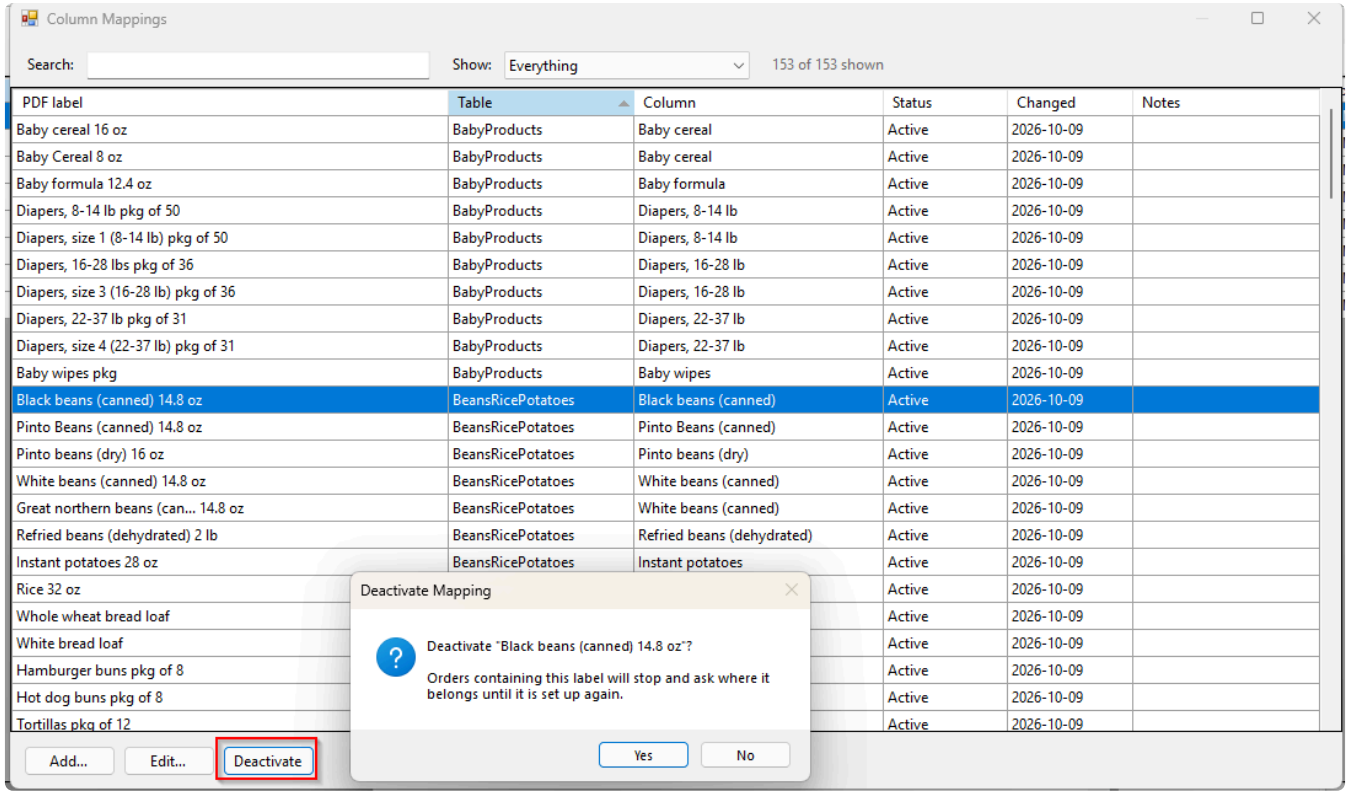
Select a row and click **Edit…**, or double-click the row. Change the table, column, Ignore or notes, then click **Save**. Required order fields cannot be edited.



Deactivating and reactivating

Mappings are never deleted. Instead:

1. Select the row and click **Deactivate**.
2. Confirm with **Yes**. Orders containing this label will now stop and ask where it belongs.
3. To turn it back on, select it and click **Reactivate** (the same button).



Every add, edit, deactivate and reactivate is recorded in the import log.

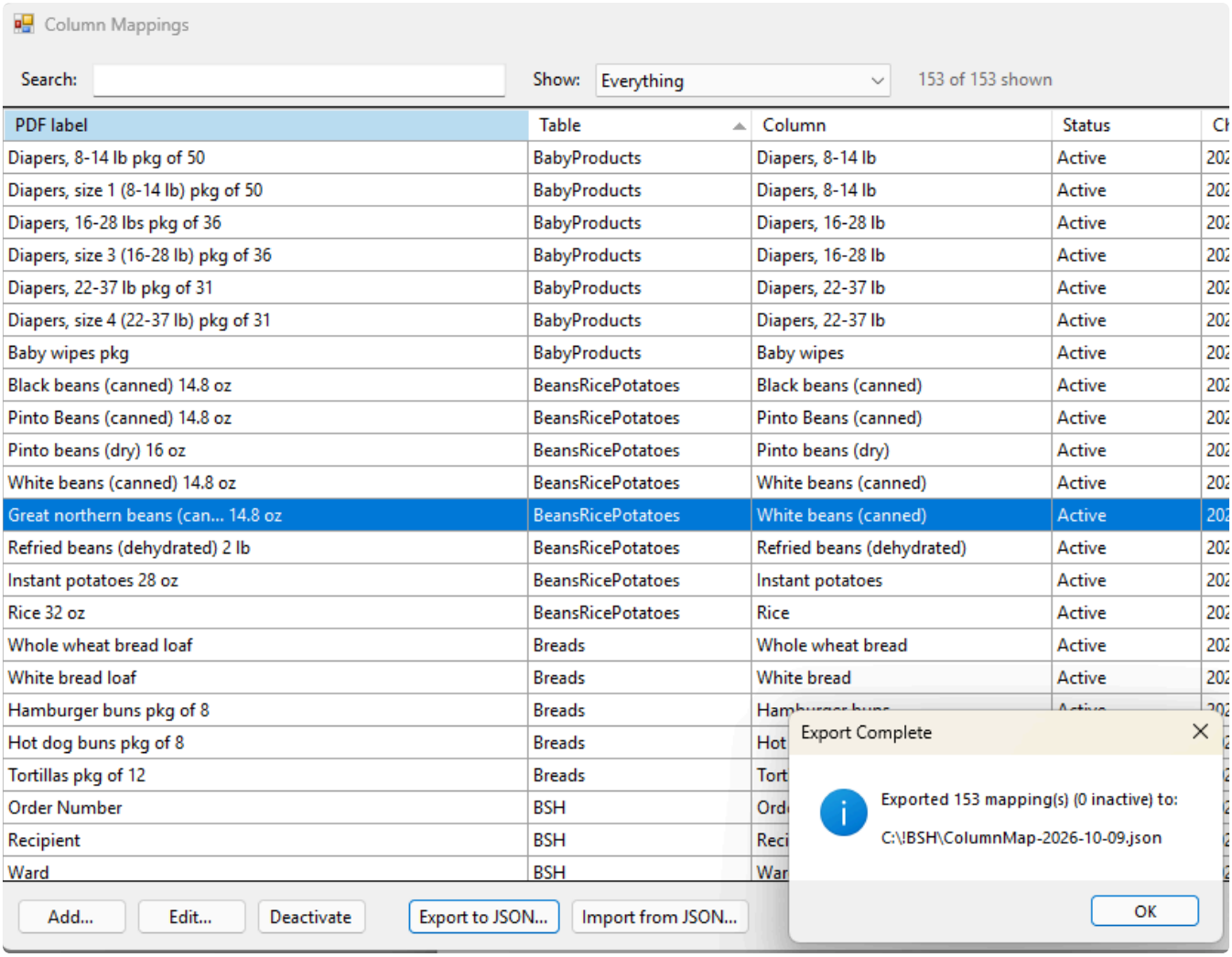
Backing up and copying mappings

Export saves every mapping to a JSON file; Import applies a JSON file to the current database. Use them to back up mappings, or to copy them from one database to another. Both buttons are on the Column Mappings screen.

Exporting

1. Click **Export to JSON...**.
2. Choose where to save. The file name defaults to `ColumnMap-` plus today's date, for example `ColumnMap-2026-10-09.json`.
3. Click **Save**. **Export Complete** shows how many mappings were saved and how many are inactive.

The file includes every mapping: active, inactive, ignored, and their notes.

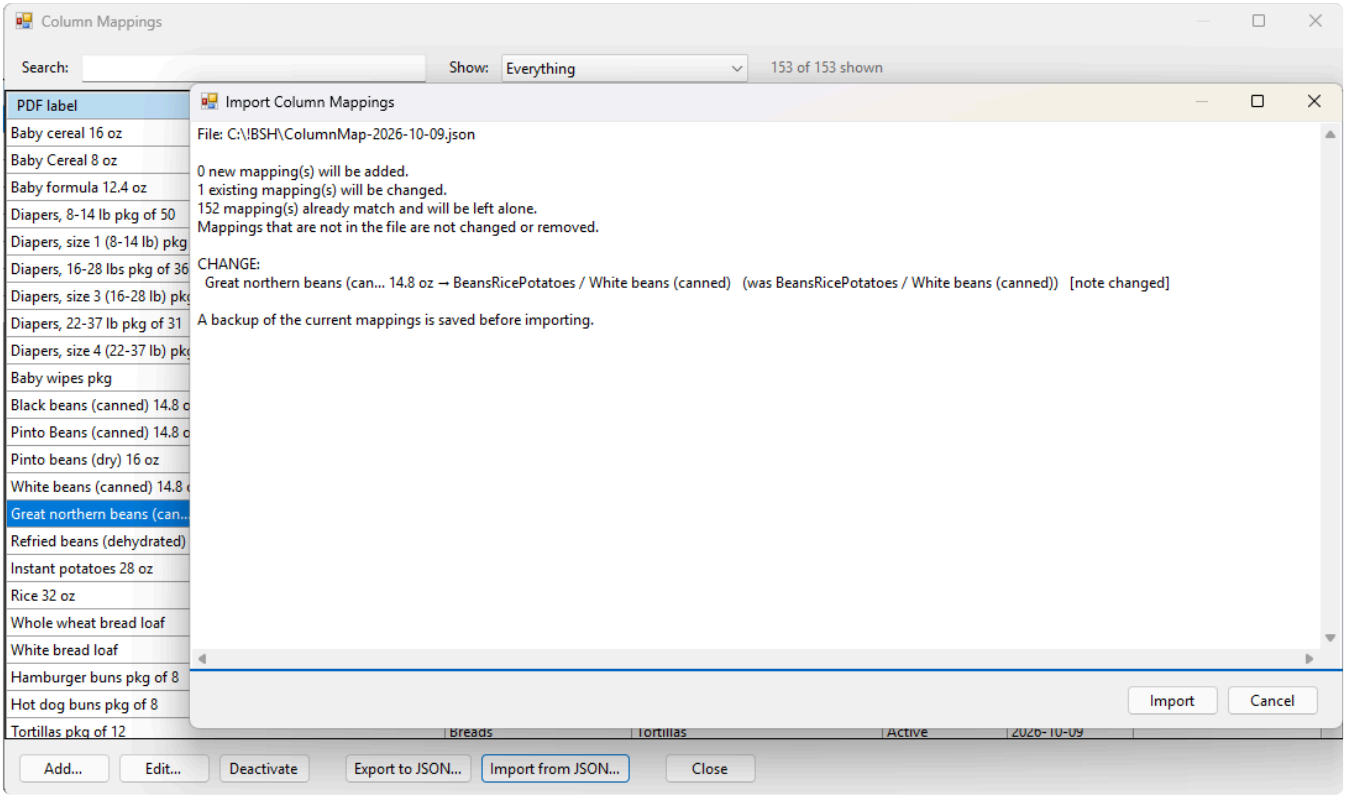


Importing

1. Click **Import from JSON...** and pick a JSON file.
2. Read the preview. It lists how many mappings will be added, changed, or left alone, then each ADD and CHANGE line. A change shows what the mapping was before. Anything in the file that cannot be used is listed under SKIPPED.
3. Click **Import** to apply, or **Cancel**.

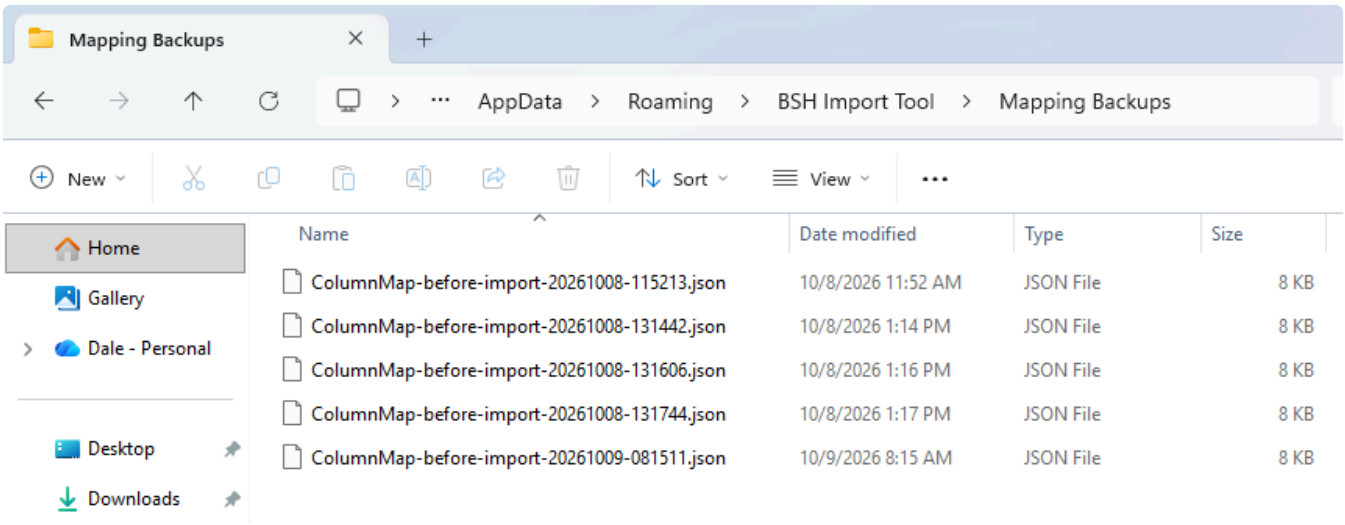
What Import does and does not do:

- Each mapping in the file keeps its active or inactive state and its note.
- Mappings in the database that are not in the file are left alone. Nothing is removed.
- Before applying, the app saves a backup of the current mappings. If the backup fails, nothing is imported.
- If the file matches the database already, you see **Nothing to Import**.



Undoing an import

Backups are saved to `%AppData%\BSH Import Tool\Mapping Backups`, named `ColumnMap-before-import-` plus the date and time. To undo an import, import that backup file.

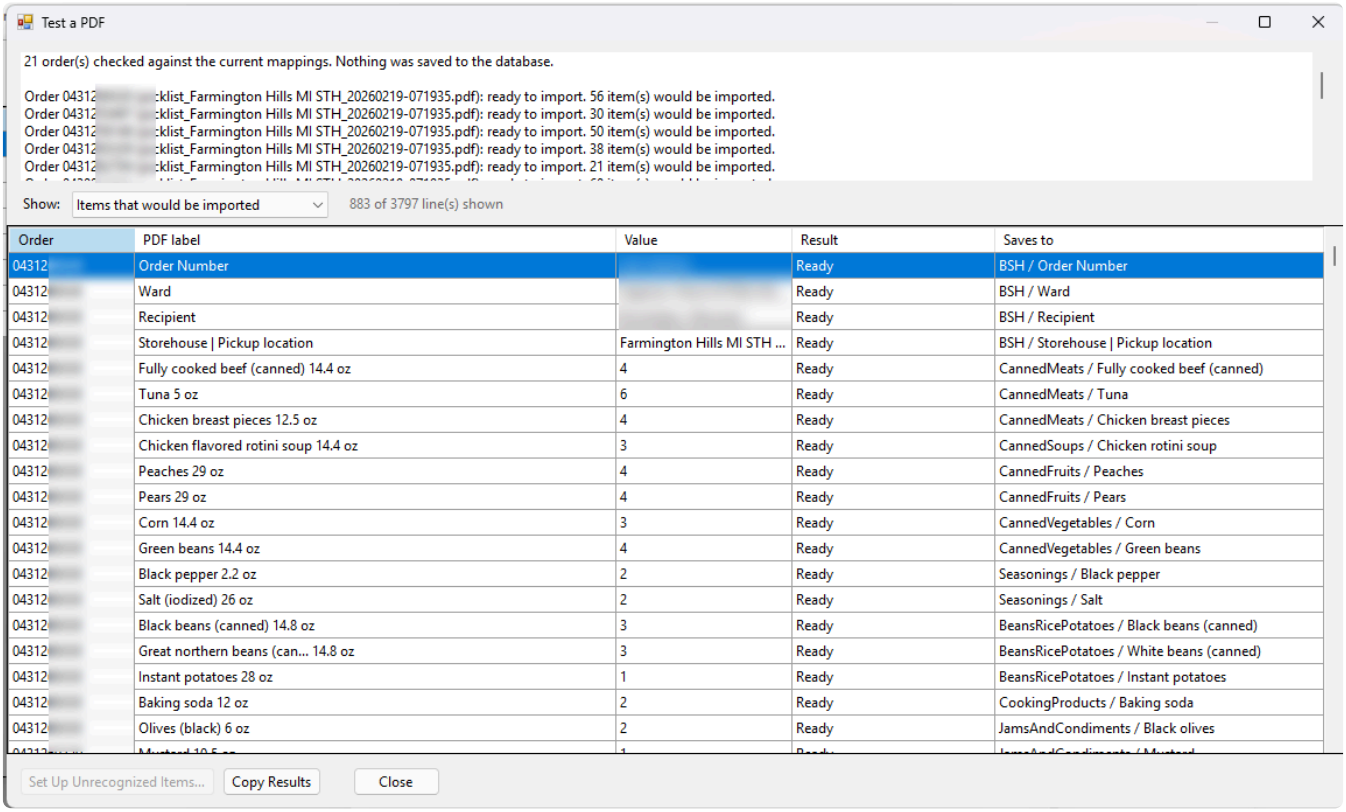


Test a PDF

Menu → Test a PDF… shows what an import *would* do, without saving any orders. Use it to check a new version of the order form, or a large picklist, before importing for real.

Steps

1. Click **Menu → Test a PDF…**.
2. Pick one or more order forms or picklists and click **Open**. Picklists are split into orders just like an import.
3. The **Test a PDF** window opens with a summary at the top and the PDF lines below.



The summary

One line per order tells you what an import would do:

- **ready to import**, with the number of items that would be saved
- **items not set up**: the import would stop and ask about them
- **other item(s) on the form are not set up (not ordered)**: items on the form that aren't set up, but this order didn't include them. They don't stop this import; the first order that includes one would stop

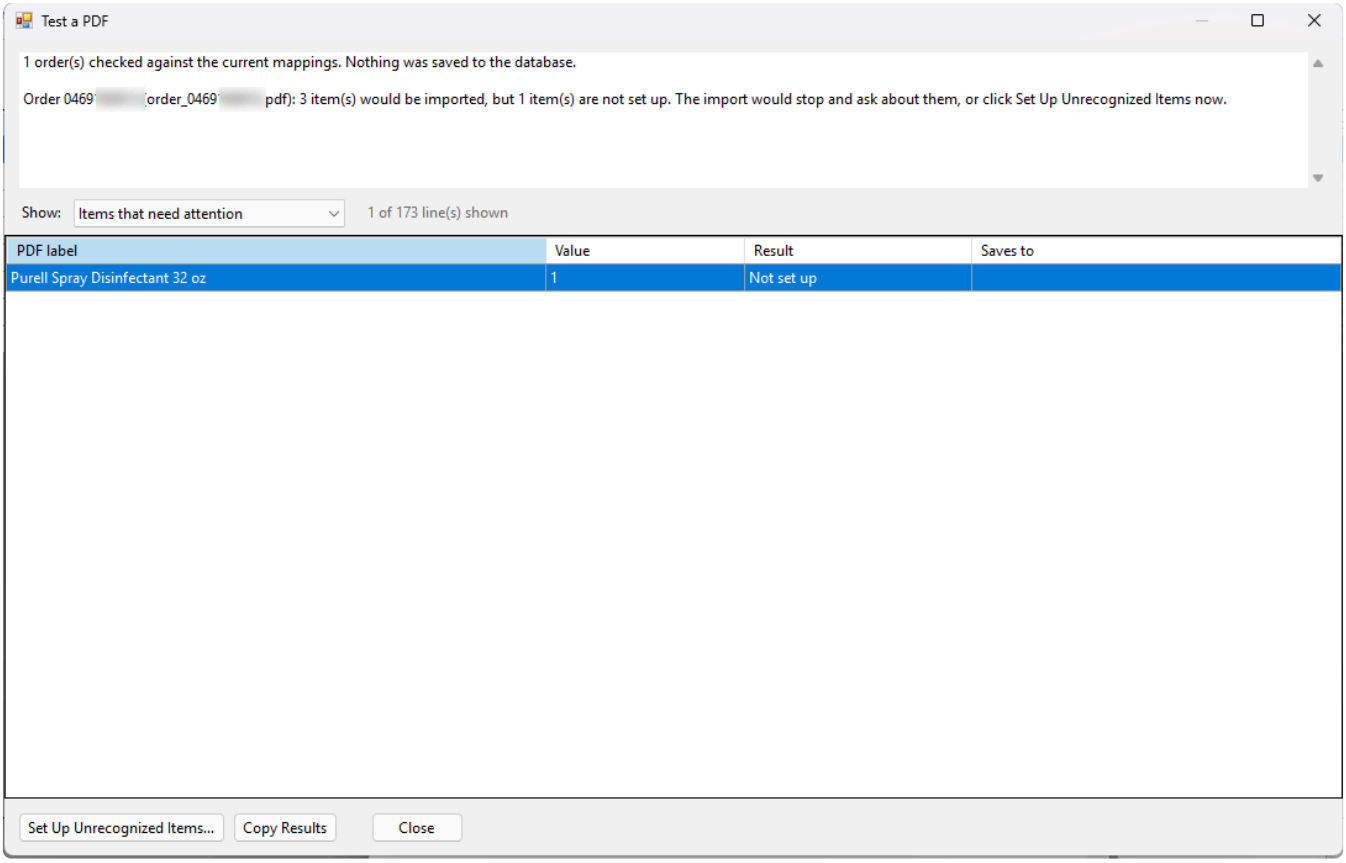
- **already in the database**: the import would skip it
- **no order number was found**: the import would reject the file as not an order form

The line-by-line list

Each line from the PDF shows its **PDF label**, **Value**, **Result** and where it **Saves to** (table / column). When you test several orders, an **Order** column is added.

Result	Meaning
Ready	Will be saved to the table and column shown.
Not set up	No mapping. Blocks the import. Shown in red.
Column missing in database	The mapping points to a column that no longer exists. Blocks the import. Shown in red.
Not set up (not ordered)	An item on the form with no mapping, but this order didn't include it. Doesn't block this import. Shown in orange.
Column missing (not ordered)	An item on the form whose mapping points to a column that no longer exists, but this order didn't include it. Doesn't block this import. Shown in orange.
Ignored	You marked this label Ignore.
Ignored (built in)	Always skipped, such as `Address` or `# in household`.
Skipped (no quantity)	Nothing was ordered on this line.

Use **Show** to filter the list: Items that need attention, Items that would be imported, Ignored labels, or Every line in the PDF. Items that need attention includes the not-ordered items. It opens on the problems when there are any.



Fixing problems from the test

Click **Set Up Unrecognized Items…** to open the same Unrecognized Items window an import uses, with every item that needs attention from all tested orders, including the not-ordered ones. After you save, the test runs again and the results refresh. The button is greyed out when nothing needs attention.

Copying the results

Copy Results copies the summary and every line to the clipboard, tab-separated, so you can paste them into Excel or an email.

Troubleshooting and FAQ

Problem	What to do
Orders went into the wrong database	Check the title bar. Use **Menu → Access Database Location** to switch.

"Column Mapping Error" at startup	The mappings could not be loaded, so no orders can be imported. Close Access if you have the database open, then restart the app. If it keeps happening, contact your administrator.
"No Column Mappings" at startup	The database has no mappings yet. Contact your administrator.
An item was saved under the wrong table	Open Column Mappings, find the label, click **Edit…** and fix it. Then ask your administrator to correct the order that was already imported.
The same item keeps asking to be set up	Its mapping may be inactive. Show **Inactive** on the Column Mappings screen and click **Reactivate**.
A row is red on Column Mappings	The column was renamed or removed in Access. Edit the mapping and pick the new column.
A new form version has new wording	Run **Test a PDF** on it first and set up the new items before importing, including any marked Not set up (not ordered).
A new item has no table or column to pick	Tick Not in database and save. Paste the copied note into an email to your administrator. Once they've added it, import the order again.
"Required order field" can't be changed	Order Number, Recipient, Ward and Storehouse are fixed. If one is wrong, contact your administrator.
I undid something by mistake	Import the latest file from the Mapping Backups folder, or an earlier export.

Files the app uses

File	Location
Import log	`%AppData%\BSH Import Tool\import_log.txt`
Mapping backups	`%AppData%\BSH Import Tool\Mapping Backups`
Mappings	Saved in the BSH database

To open `%AppData%`, type it in the File Explorer address bar and press **Enter**.